

Republicans' outlook is remarkably stable

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-09-05 01:12

【メール原文】

This week in polling: Republicans' outlook is remarkably stable. There wasn't much change in the macro-political environment this week. President Dona|||||||

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Despite Trump's overtures, US-North Korea summit remains unlikely.

This week in polling: Republicans' outlook is remarkably stable. There wasn't much change in the macro-political environment this week. President Donald Trump's approval rating is still languishing between 38% and 39%, per Silver Bulletin, and Democrats' lead in the generic congressional ballot was stable in the mid-6%.

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What is most remarkable about this midterm race, so far, is its high-level stability; neither Trump's approval rating or the generic ballot have moved much over the summer, and there's no indication they will do so over the next two months, either. Indeed, the generic ballot tends not to move much in the final two months of the campaign. That points to this being a race that will be decided in the states, in which the quality of candidates and campaigns, the spending battle, and maneuvering on individual issues (such as data centers) are decisive.

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In Iowa, Republicans had one of their better polls across all Senate battlegrounds: Emerson found GOP candidate Ashley Hinson leading Democrat Josh Turek by 5 points, the third poll in a row showing Hinson with a small but durable lead. Iowa voted for Trump by 13 points in 2024, so a 5-point lead for the Republican is exactly in line with a national environment eight points to the left of 2024 and in which neither candidate is running ahead of the partisan baseline. This run of polling suggests that Iowa is better than a toss-up for Republicans, even if it's not a guaranteed hold.

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The most attention-grabbing poll of the week was far afield: a University of New Hampshire poll finding Republican John Sununu leading against Democrat Rep. Chris Pappas (D-NH). New Hampshire has long been thought safe Democratic territory, due to President Trump's deep unpopularity in New England, but it's not implausible Sununu—assuming he wins the primary next week, in which he is the heavy

favorite—can be competitive: A former senator, he comes from a political dynasty in the state renowned for its middle-of-the-road approach, and Pappas’s record is not that of a gifted campaigner who outperforms the fundamentals. Still, New Hampshire’s blue tinge means we’d want to see a few more polls showing Sununu tied or ahead before we move this race into a more competitive tier.

US-China AI dialogue likely to fall short in resolving disputes over technology competition. Expectations around a US-China AI dialogue in the run-up to the summit between Trump and President Xi Jinping on 24 September are falling. The two sides have reportedly yet to agree on a date, agenda, or participants for the discussion, and Beijing’s skepticism of Washington’s intentions appears to be growing.

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Beijing is arguing that US companies should not unilaterally dictate AI safety rules. On 31 August, Chinese state media criticized the US’s rules-setting approach and set two conditions for substantive talks: Washington must distinguish legitimate technology competition from security threats and apply equivalent safety and audit requirements to both US and Chinese AI firms. Washington, in turn, has aimed to manage tensions by keeping the summit’s focus on mutually agreeable items.

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Relatedly, if dialogue advances, it is likely to remain confined to narrow technical issues. Beijing wants technical engagement on issues such as cyber-risks, definition of frontier models, and misuse by non-state actors. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who will likely lead the US side, has framed the dialogue in ways consistent with Beijing’s preferences, such as emphasizing safety guardrails to prevent frontier models from being controlled by criminal or terrorist organizations. While Beijing views AI safety discussions as an extension of US technology-containment policy, Bessent’s careful phrasing reflects his intent to keep the summit on track by assuaging the Chinese side’s anxiety that the summit will tail-spin into a confrontation that is harmful for Xi’s optics. However, Bessent’s actions are a singular tactic and are not necessarily reflective of the US side’s negotiating strategy.

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Frictions over US norms-setting also flared at the G20. On 1 September, China opposed language in the G20 communique introduced by the US that called for the elimination of “non-market policies” that exacerbate global imbalances. Beijing may see this year’s G20 leaders’ summit as a US vehicle for building international consensus against China’s trade and industrial policies, increasing Chinese reservations around Xi’s attendance.

Despite Trump’s overtures, US-North Korea summit remains unlikely. President Trump’s sudden decision to reduce joint US-South Korea military exercises last month was a low-cost effort to kickstart talks with North Korean leader Kim Jong-un. Trump will, however, be reluctant to offer much more, including overturning decades of US policy toward North Korea’s nuclear weapons program.

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South Korea was alarmed at Trump’s unilateral decision to reduce joint training exercises last month, but Seoul supports Washington’s renewed outreach to North Korea and push to reduce tensions on the Korean Peninsula (see Congress to address debt ceiling in lame duck or after, 18 August 2026).

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While a recent softening of positions has prompted speculation of a US-North Korea meeting, a summit between Trump and North Korean leader Kim Jong-un remains unlikely to come together by the time Trump next travels to Asia in November.

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Kim is in a significantly stronger geopolitical position than during Trump's first term, and he will likely demand a cancellation of US-South Korea joint military exercises or recognition of North Korea's nuclear program before returning to the negotiating table—concessions that Trump is unlikely to offer.

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For more, see Obstacles to Trump-Kim summit likely insurmountable in near term, 3 September 2026.

Quote of the Day

"We are, I think, nicely trying to encourage people to do their balloting as quickly as possible, and that means hiring additional staff so that it doesn't call into question results." – Rep. Joe Morelle (D-NY) as quoted by Politico. Morelle's comments reflect Democrats' efforts to get ahead of the Trump administration and prepare for potential attempts to interfere in the November elections. However, while Trump has theoretical levers to complicate the midterm results, he cannot cancel or meaningfully delay the elections; at most, he can delay the certainty of the results (see Trump's post-Greenland focus on Canada creates opportunities for Mexico, 23 January 2026).

On the Radar

10 August – 14 September: Senate on recess

8 September: Canadian retaliatory tariffs go into effect

9-10 September: GOP midterms convention

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

30 September: Government funding runs out

3 November: National midterm elections

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